might get sucked into the world of crime and violence. "MAD was born because I was angry at society, where instead of providing children with the best care and support they need to break free of the cycle of poverty, we are just keeping them alive till 18 and then washing our hands of them," says Nedumula.

Today, MAD gives Nedumala the greatest satisfaction. The NGO has worked with around 20,000 volunteers in the past 17 years, building a model that can help children escape inter-generational poverty. "We realised that simply teaching children English would not help—many of them still went on to get arrested for selling drugs, got into toxic relationships, were suicidal or had mental health issues," says Nedumula. So, MAD built a holistic programme wherein along with providing for their basic needs, children also receive exposure to build life skills and essential personality traits.

HAPPINESS MANTRA

"To experience deeper happiness, invest long-term in helping others"

— JITHIN NEDUMALA, Founder, MAD

Today, the first generation of children that Nedumula taught are all adults; most of them are married and earn Rs 20,000 to Rs 25,000 a month on average. MAD has also provided them with interest-free funding to build their first home. The cost will be paid back into a kitty that will go towards building homes for the next batch. Nedumala calls it a "cycle of support and happiness".

For many of MAD's volunteers, there is a special joy that comes from a decade-long relationship with a child. "I won't say I have helped thousands of children. I have made a difference to the 10 children I have personally worked with for over a decade now. They are family to me and that relationship continuously makes me happy," says Nedumula. ■



MAKING IT POSSIBLE
Vidya Rajput at a beautician training course in Raipur

BHUPESH KESHARWANI

The Gender Warrior

***Happiness delivery:** A third-gender rights crusader in Chhattisgarh strives to ensure that the members of her community live with dignity*

By **RAHUL NORONHA**